Collaborative Essay Practice

Group Member Names:

Discussion Facilitator: _____

Scribe: _____

Rubric & Checklist Expert: _____

Accountability & Timekeeping: _____

Prompt: What were the goals and priorities of the founders in drafting and ratifying the Constitution?

Step 1: Analyze the prompt. First, rewrite it in your own words:

What did the people who wrote and approved the Constitution want it to do, and what mattered most to them? **Goals and priorities** = what they wanted, and what they cared about MOST (rank them); **Founders** = the delegates in Philadelphia, plus the Federalists and Antifederalists; **Drafting** = writing it in 1787; **Ratifying** = getting the states to approve it, 1787 to 1788, Bill of Rights 1791

Step 2: When you are answering, think of this as a spectrum. Identify the three options you can argue:

Not a "to what extent" prompt, so the options are the three main answers you could give.

Option 1: A strong national government, fix the Articles of Confederation, which were too weak to tax or keep order

Option 2: Protect liberty and prevent tyranny, never repeat British rule

Option 3: Balance: strong but limited, both at once, which is the strongest answer ← we argue this

Step 3: Gather evidence before deciding which side to argue:

	Evidence	Which option from step 2 does this support and why?
Option 1	**Weak Articles of Confederation** Congress couldn't tax or keep order; Shays' Rebellion (1786) scared leaders.	Option 1: they needed a government strong enough to work.
Option 2	**Preamble** "We the People" (popular sovereignty) and "secure the Blessings of Liberty".	Option 2: power comes from the people, and liberty is the goal.
Option 3	**Separation of powers and checks and balances** Montesquieu: Articles I, II, III. Veto, 2/3 override, Senate confirms judges, House impeaches, Senate convicts with 2/3.	Option 3: power, but split so no one abuses it.
Option 4	**Federalists' clauses** Hamilton and Madison: Necessary and Proper Clause, Commerce Clause, Supremacy Clause (Article VI).	Option 1: a stronger national government.
Option 5	**Antifederalists and the Bill of Rights** They only ratified if promised a Bill of Rights (1791). 10th Amendment reserves powers to the states or the people.	Option 2: liberty was made a priority equal to power.

Step 4: Draft your response, using the rubric and checklist to guide how you construct your argument

Context: The background information that shows your reader why this topic is significant by answering key questions like who, what, where, when, and why. Aim to write at least 3 connected context sentences before reaching your thesis statement.
After the Revolution, the Articles of Confederation left the national government too weak to tax, pay its debts or keep order. In 1787 delegates met in Philadelphia to write a new constitution. They had to balance two fears: a government too weak to function, and one so strong it would repeat British tyranny.

Thesis: Clearly answer the prompt by claiming (arguing) something. Provide a clear outline of what you will discuss in your body paragraph. [Claim] because [Supporting Argument 1] and Y [Supporting Argument 2].
The founders' main goal was a national government strong enough to work but limited enough that it could never become a tyranny, because they built it on Enlightenment ideas about natural rights and popular sovereignty, and because the Antifederalists forced them to protect individual liberty in a Bill of Rights.

Evidence 1: Remember TEA: Begin with a TOPIC SENTENCE, then introduce your EVIDENCE (facts and examples that support your argument) in the following sentences. Then through ANALYSIS, explain why the evidence matters and how it proves your thesis.
Topic: One major reason is that the founders built the government on Enlightenment ideas.
Evidence: The Preamble begins with "We the People," showing popular sovereignty, and promises to "secure the Blessings of Liberty." Following Montesquieu, Articles I, II and III separate power into three branches, and checks and balances let each limit the others: the President can veto, Congress can override with 2/3 of both houses, and the Senate confirms judges.
Analysis: This shows the founders cared more about preventing abuse of power than about speed. Splitting power three ways protects natural rights, which proves their priority was a limited government.

Evidence 2: Remember TEA: Begin with a TOPIC SENTENCE, then introduce your EVIDENCE (facts and examples that support your argument) in the following sentences. Then through ANALYSIS, explain why the evidence matters and how it proves your thesis.
Topic: Another reason is the debate between the Federalists and the Antifederalists.
Evidence: Federalists like Hamilton and Madison wanted a stronger national government, with the Necessary and Proper Clause, the Commerce Clause and the Supremacy Clause in Article VI. Antifederalists feared it would abuse its power and would only ratify if promised a Bill of Rights, added in 1791, and the 10th Amendment reserved every other power to the states or the people.
Analysis: This shows the final Constitution was a compromise: strong because of the Federalists and protective because of the Antifederalists, so liberty became a priority equal to power.

Alternative Perspective: Remember TEA: Begin with a TOPIC SENTENCE, then introduce your EVIDENCE (in this case, the evidence that someone arguing the other perspective would say) in the following sentences. Then through ANALYSIS, explain why the evidence matters, but why ultimately your argument is stronger than the other perspective.
Topic: Critics argue that the founders mainly protected the property and power of wealthy white men.
Evidence: Slavery stayed legal through the Three Fifths Compromise, and at first only some men could vote.
Analysis: That is true to an extent. However, the founders also wrote Article V so the Constitution could change, which later allowed the 13th, 14th and 15th Amendments. Their priority was a government built to govern and built to grow.

Conclusion (not on the class sheet, but the essay needs one): The founders' priority was balance: enough power to govern, with enough limits to protect liberty. That balance is why the same framework still works more than 230 years later.